

EYEWITNESS 1960s

A Place to Party

For those stationed at big, permanent bases, life was often a far cry from the typical image of being in a war zone. Many young men took advantage of the facilities to enjoy their time on base—as was the case for Pete Whalon of Redondo Beach, California, who extended his tour to serve as a lifeguard at one of the 12 pools on Long Binh Post.

With its cold beer, loud music, absence of lifers (career soldiers), and lack of rules, the pool (nicknamed the Bayou) soon became the coolest place to party. In his account, Whalon describes a typical evening at the Bayou with up to thirty drunks in and around the pool as music blasted from the Sugar Shack. Marathon sessions of Monopoly would take place in the Shack and there were rowdy water-football games. The smell of marijuana was heavy in the air and four maverick military policemen (MPs) had assured them that they would never get busted for smoking marijuana while the four MPs were in country. Empty beer cans and wine bottles were strewn across the ground. There were very few restrictions and every night was an open-pool party.

“I often felt as though I was hosting a perpetual, out-of-control frat party—seven nights a week.”

PETE WHALON, IN HIS MEMOIR, *THE SAIGON ZOO: VIETNAM'S OTHER WAR: SEX, DRUGS, ROCK 'N ROLL: A VERY DIFFERENT VIETNAM MEMOIR*, 2006